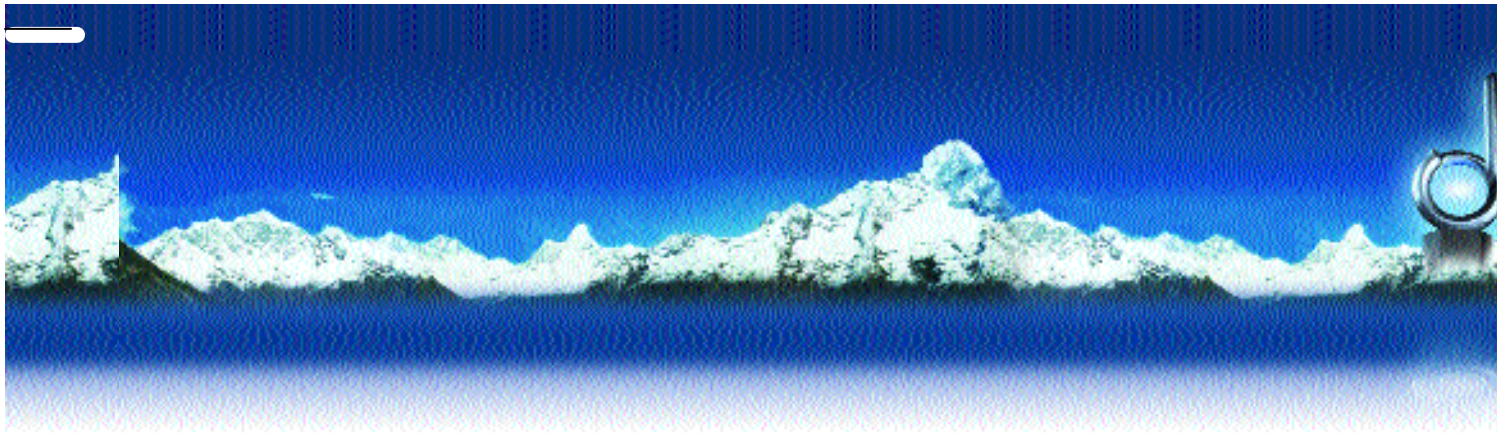
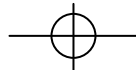




SCANNERS

In today's age of free Web sites and Web-based image hosting services, it would be great to port all your memories to a lasting digital format to be viewed by your relatives around the world. Scanners enable this and with increasing resolutions, vivid colours, smaller form factors and low prices, it is easier than ever to embark on your digital imaging journey.

Get the picture

Since scanners are used to convert photographs and printed documents into digital format, their performance is largely dependant upon the resolution, the colour depth and the speed offered. The primary factors that affect the quality of the scanner are the resolution along with the colour depth supported. For most entry-level scanners, a 600x1200 dpi resolution is a good start as it can scan with a maximum optical resolution of 600 dpi.

The most crucial scanner specification is the optical resolution—this is the true resolution with which the scanner operates. Second comes the interpolated or software resolution—this is the resolution at which the scanner increases its resolution and creates the in-between scan points by 'guessing' their value using algorithms in software. Therefore, the interpolated resolution will not necessarily have the same clarity as an optical scan. The scanning resolution decides the size of your scanned image as well as the size it is converted to as a graphic file.

The other important parameter that decides the image quality is the colour depth. As a rule of thumb, the higher the colour depth, the greater is the scanner's ability to reproduce true-to-life colours. Go for a scanner with a colour depth of at least 48 bits. During the scanning process, information is generally lost and therefore, if the scanner can sense a greater number of colours, the greater is its ability to capture the original colour.

Another important parameter

Nominees

Name	Contacts	Comments
Microtek ScanMaker X12USL	Rashi Peripherals, Ph: 022-28260258	Built around a 1200x2400, 48-bit scanning engine, this Legal-size scanner is ideally suited to applications where large documents need to be scanned at the highest quality.
HP ScanJet 5400	Hewlett-Packard India Ltd, Ph: 080-5216121	Featuring a 2400x2400 resolution and 48-bit colour support, this scanner exhibited very good performance characteristics in photo and text.

of a scanner is its scanning speed. This is decided by the motor used to advance the scanning element and the interface of the scanner to the computer. Some brands offer inherently better implementations of the scanning engine, allowing them to scan faster without sacrificing on quality. Therefore, before purchasing a scanner, take a test scan using different modes such as photo quality, monochrome, etc.

Finally, the other factor that affects the scanning speed is the interface—choose a scanner with a USB interface as this offers much higher speeds compared to parallel port scanner.

And the award goes to...



The scanner that delivered outstanding scanning quality was the HP ScanJet 5400.

With its support for true 24-bit colour and 48-bit colour depth, this scanner shows excellent results in colour and clarity. Added functionality, it has 11 preset tasks that can invoke a range of tasks you use the scanner as a copier, have a printer connected, also a range of other cross-application shortcut keys.



HP Scanjet 5470C

Hewlett-Packard India Ltd, Ph: 080- 5216121

The verdict: With its robust 2400x2400 scanning resolution, coupled with a 48-bit colour depth and a host of intuitive controls, this scanner delivered stellar performance

OCR SOFTWARE

ABBY FineReader 6.0 CE

In the OCR software segment, ABBY FineReader 6.0 CE logged 96 per cent accuracy in identifying words. This application is a brilliant solution for getting all those hardcopies and newspaper clippings into editable document format. The factor that set it apart from others was that it managed to retain even the formatting in the document—even newspaper and magazine pages were correctly reproduced. The

application created an editable document that retained the columns, images, formatting and even the fonts in the original document with unparalleled accuracy.



ABBY FineReader 6.0 CE

Net Spider, Ph: 022-28260258

The verdict: This OCR software offers unmatched capability in recognising documents. It is also able to retain formatting faithfully, and is your best bet for digitising your printed documents